

United Airlines

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SUBJECT: UNITED APP FEATURE TO HELP PASSENGERS MITIGATE DELAYS

United Airlines can boost its customer satisfaction by developing a feature on its app called *ClearPath* that warns passengers about the likelihood of flight delays and allows them to rebook their flight (to and from the same airport) free of charge. This solution directly addresses the -90 and -45 NPS dropoffs that come from untimely delay notifications and difficulty in rebooking delayed flights. *ClearPath's* accessible, customer-facing services will not only increase customer satisfaction, but also save United cancellation costs and relieve its customer service agents, especially at its busiest hubs and in times of inclement weather, where some delays are unavoidable. Combined with United's current efforts to identify operations deficiencies and replace its legacy Unimatic software, *ClearPath* will empower United to drive an operationally sustainable and customer-centric future for the "United Next" strategy.

BACKGROUND:

United Airlines currently stands as one of the four primary leaders in the U.S. airline industry, with a 16% market share and the largest global fleet. The airline is in the fifth year of its "United Next" strategy centered around high asset utilization and efficiency-driven premiumization. So far, the initiative has yielded the following results:

- 10% increase in flight offerings. This has included ramping up operations at its core hubs such as ORD, which has seen an estimated 47% increase in United flight operations.
- 3.5% revenue increase from 2024 to 2025, reaching \$59.1 billion.
- 5.7% domestic capacity growth, allowing United to decrease the gap with its main competitor Delta.
- American Customer Satisfaction Index score decreases since 2023, placing United over 4 points behind its main competitors Delta and Southwest.
- United's customer satisfaction is below the industry average across all flight classes

DISCUSSION:

"United Next" is boosting United's revenue and market position, but ultimately compromising its operational reliability and customer satisfaction. With on-time performance plummeting at core hubs like ORD and EWR and the FAA capping daily operations at these core hubs and others, United must pivot its strategy from focusing on peak efficiency to fostering operational sustainability that ultimately drives high customer satisfaction. Given the massive financial costs and brand value hits that each delay incurs on the airline, United must focus on mitigating the delays that are ramping up at its core hubs.

United is currently working on several initiatives to proactively identify and mitigate the causes of delays, including high-level data collection powered by cameras and cutting-edge AI. While these initiatives will be critical in helping improve on-time performance in its core hubs, some delays will remain unavoidable, especially given the fact that United's core hubs are the busiest airports in the nation and that there are some inclement weather conditions in which airplanes simply cannot safely fly.

Given these constraints, United must additionally implement customer-centric solutions that allow them to mitigate the effects of flight delays. According to airline delay NPS analysis by Bain & Co., NPS scores critically drop off when passengers are not given timely notifications about their flight delay status and when rebooking a flight takes them over 10 minutes. With this in mind, United should develop and implement a solution that addresses these communication and system usability concerns.

RECOMMENDATION:

ClearPath by United is such a solution. Built into the existing United app, *ClearPath* will leverage cutting-edge AI to flag flights that have a medium or high risk of being delayed and send an alert to the flight's passengers via the App, SMS, and/or email. This message will be accompanied with suggested alternative flights to and from the same airport that the customer can book for free to avoid the delay. *ClearPath* is expected have the following impact:

- Alert passengers about flight delay risk before they leave for the airport, saving them hours that would otherwise be spent waiting at a busy airport gate
- Allow customers to rebook their potentially delayed flight in under a minute, for free
- A per customer NPS impact of +10, as these solutions address the main drivers of low flight delay NPS
- \$608 million in savings by Year 3, as *ClearPath*'s delay prediction AI will empower United staff to avoid delays before they even occur, relieve customer service workers during peak delay times, and restore United's brand reputation around delay mitigation.

NEXT STEPS:

To ensure a seamless development and rollout of *ClearPath*, I recommend the following actions:

- **Vendor selection:** Decide whether to build *ClearPath* in house or contract a software company to develop it and integrate it into the United app.
- **Delay data preparation:** Clean and preprocess United flight delay data to train *ClearPath*'s AI on.
- **Pilot and rollout strategy planning:** Identify airports, and flight trajectories, and times for the *ClearPath* pilot. Devise a rollout strategy that allows for seamless implementation and operational relief where it is most needed.

I am available to discuss the technical requirements and financial modeling for this initiative at your earliest convenience.

Best regards,
Daniel Rueda-Ramirez